

SPEAK LOVE

A Communication Workbook for Couples

Practical Exercises to Transform
How You Talk, Listen, and Connect

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COMMUNICATION STYLES ASSESSMENT

PARTNER A: _____ **PARTNER B:** _____

Rate each statement 1 (never) to 5 (always). Both partners answer.

I express my needs clearly	A: ____	B: ____
I listen without planning my response	A: ____	B: ____
I shut down during conflict	A: ____	B: ____
I raise my voice when frustrated	A: ____	B: ____
I bring up past issues during arguments	A: ____	B: ____
I use sarcasm when hurt	A: ____	B: ____
I validate my partner's feelings	A: ____	B: ____
I apologize when I am wrong	A: ____	B: ____
I give the silent treatment	A: ____	B: ____
I check in about my partner's day	A: ____	B: ____
I criticize my partner's character (not just behavior)	A: ____	B: ____
I use 'I' statements instead of 'you' accusations	A: ____	B: ____

MY COMMUNICATION STYLE (circle one for each partner):

Partner A: Passive / Aggressive / Passive-Aggressive / Assertive

Partner B: Passive / Aggressive / Passive-Aggressive / Assertive

OUR BIGGEST COMMUNICATION CHALLENGE:

LISTENER reflection (what I heard you say is...):

Speaker: Did they get it right? ☐ Yes ☐ Close ☐ No

What I wish they had heard:

How did it feel to be truly listened to? (1-10): ____

How did it feel to listen without responding? (1-10): ____

PRACTICE #2

SPEAKER (circle): Partner A / Partner B

Topic to share (choose something non-threatening):

LISTENER reflection (what I heard you say is...):

Speaker: Did they get it right? ☐ Yes ☐ Close ☐ No

What I wish they had heard:

How did it feel to be truly listened to? (1-10): ____

How did it feel to listen without responding? (1-10): ____

What I wish they had heard:

How did it feel to be truly listened to? (1-10): ____

How did it feel to listen without responding? (1-10): ____

PRACTICE #4

SPEAKER (circle): Partner A / Partner B

Topic to share (choose something non-threatening):

LISTENER reflection (what I heard you say is...):

Speaker: Did they get it right? ☐ Yes ☐ Close ☐ No

What I wish they had heard:

How did it feel to be truly listened to? (1-10): ____

How did it feel to listen without responding? (1-10): ____

What I wish they had heard:

How did it feel to be truly listened to? (1-10): ____

How did it feel to listen without responding? (1-10): ____

PRACTICE #6

SPEAKER (circle): Partner A / Partner B

Topic to share (choose something non-threatening):

LISTENER reflection (what I heard you say is...):

Speaker: Did they get it right? ☐ Yes ☐ Close ☐ No

What I wish they had heard:

How did it feel to be truly listened to? (1-10): ____

How did it feel to listen without responding? (1-10): ____

SITUATION #1

When: _____

I feel: _____

Because: _____

I need: _____

Full I-Statement (put it all together):_____

Partner response: 'I hear you. What I can do is...'

SITUATION #2

When: _____

I feel: _____

Because: _____

I need: _____

Full I-Statement (put it all together):_____

Partner response: 'I hear you. What I can do is...'

SITUATION #3

When: _____

I feel: _____

Because: _____

I need: _____

Full I-Statement (put it all together):_____

Partner response: 'I hear you. What I can do is...'

I need: _____

Full I-Statement (put it all together):

Partner response: 'I hear you. What I can do is...' _____

SITUATION #5

When: _____

I feel: _____

Because: _____

I need: _____

Full I-Statement (put it all together):

Partner response: 'I hear you. What I can do is...' _____

SITUATION #6

When: _____

I feel: _____

Because: _____

I need: _____

Full I-Statement (put it all together):

Partner response: 'I hear you. What I can do is...' _____

I need: _____

Full I-Statement (put it all together):

Partner response: 'I hear you. What I can do is...' _____

SITUATION #8

When: _____

I feel: _____

Because: _____

I need: _____

Full I-Statement (put it all together):

Partner response: 'I hear you. What I can do is...' _____

SITUATION #9

When: _____

I feel: _____

Because: _____

I need: _____

Full I-Statement (put it all together):

Partner response: 'I hear you. What I can do is...' _____

I need: _____

Full I-Statement (put it all together):

Partner response: 'I hear you. What I can do is...' _____

SITUATION #11

When: _____

I feel: _____

Because: _____

I need: _____

Full I-Statement (put it all together):

Partner response: 'I hear you. What I can do is...' _____

SITUATION #12

When: _____

I feel: _____

Because: _____

I need: _____

Full I-Statement (put it all together):

Partner response: 'I hear you. What I can do is...' _____

I need: _____

Full I-Statement (put it all together):

Partner response: 'I hear you. What I can do is...' _____

SITUATION #14

When: _____

I feel: _____

Because: _____

I need: _____

Full I-Statement (put it all together):

Partner response: 'I hear you. What I can do is...' _____

SITUATION #15

When: _____

I feel: _____

Because: _____

I need: _____

Full I-Statement (put it all together):

Partner response: 'I hear you. What I can do is...' _____

DE-ESCALATION SCRIPT 1

SCENARIO: FINANCES - 'You spent too much again'

Instead of: 'You are so irresponsible with money!'

Try: 'I feel anxious when unexpected charges appear. Can we look at our budget together this weekend?'

YOUR TURN - Write your own script for this scenario:

What usually happens in our version of this conflict:

My de-escalating response:

My partner's de-escalating response:

Our agreed solution:

DE-ESCALATION SCRIPT 2

SCENARIO: PARENTING - 'You undermined me in front of the kids'

Instead of: 'You always make me the bad guy!'

Try: 'I felt unsupported when my decision was changed in front of the kids. Can we agree to discuss parenting decisions privately first?'

YOUR TURN - Write your own script for this scenario:

What usually happens in our version of this conflict:

My de-escalating response:

My partner's de-escalating response:

Our agreed solution:

DE-ESCALATION SCRIPT 3

SCENARIO: HOUSEHOLD - 'You never help around here'

Instead of: 'I do EVERYTHING and you just sit there!'

Try: 'I feel overwhelmed by the amount of housework. I need us to create a fair system together. When can we talk about it?'

YOUR TURN - Write your own script for this scenario:

What usually happens in our version of this conflict:

My de-escalating response:

My partner's de-escalating response:

Our agreed solution:

DE-ESCALATION SCRIPT 4

SCENARIO: INTIMACY - 'You never want to be close to me'

Instead of: 'You obviously do not find me attractive anymore.'

Try: 'I miss feeling close to you. I feel disconnected when we go a long time without physical affection. What do you need to feel more connected?'

YOUR TURN - Write your own script for this scenario:

What usually happens in our version of this conflict:

My de-escalating response:

My partner's de-escalating response:

Our agreed solution:

DE-ESCALATION SCRIPT 5

SCENARIO: IN-LAWS - 'Your mother is too involved in our life'

Instead of: 'Your mother is controlling and you let her!'

Try: 'I feel our marriage needs more privacy. When your mom weighs in on our decisions, I feel like we are not a team.

Can we set boundaries together?'

YOUR TURN - Write your own script for this scenario:

What usually happens in our version of this conflict:

My de-escalating response:

My partner's de-escalating response:

Our agreed solution:

REPAIR ATTEMPTS MENU

Repair attempts are phrases that de-escalate conflict.

Use them when a conversation is getting heated.

1. 'I am getting flooded. Can we take a 20-minute break?'
2. 'I am sorry. That came out wrong. Let me try again.'
3. 'I can see your point.'
4. 'We are on the same team here.'
5. 'I love you even when we disagree.'
6. 'Can we start over?'
7. 'Tell me what you need right now.'
8. 'I am feeling defensive. Give me a moment.'
9. 'You are more important to me than being right.'
10. 'I hear you. I may not agree yet, but I hear you.'
11. 'What can I do right now to help?'
12. 'I am scared this will turn into a fight.'
13. 'Can we agree to disagree on this one?'
14. 'I appreciate you telling me how you feel.'
15. 'Please be gentle with me right now.'
16. 'I want to understand. Say more about that.'
17. 'Let us find a compromise we both can live with.'
18. 'I was wrong. I am sorry.'
19. 'Can I have a do-over?'
20. 'One thing I love about you is...'

OUR TOP 5 REPAIR PHRASES (circle favorites above):

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____
4. _____
5. _____

WEEKLY CHECK-IN - WEEK 1

Date: ___/___/___ Set aside 20 min. No phones. Face each other.

ROSES (good things this week):

Partner A: _____

Partner B: _____

THORNS (challenges this week):

Partner A: _____

Partner B: _____

BUDS (things to look forward to):

Together: _____

APPRECIATION (one specific thing I appreciated about you):

A to B: _____

B to A: _____

NEEDS (one thing I need from you next week):

A: _____

B: _____

WEEKLY CHECK-IN - WEEK 2

Date: ____/____/____ Set aside 20 min. No phones. Face each other.

ROSES (good things this week):

Partner A: _____

Partner B: _____

THORNS (challenges this week):

Partner A: _____

Partner B: _____

BUDS (things to look forward to):

Together: _____

APPRECIATION (one specific thing I appreciated about you):

A to B: _____

B to A: _____

NEEDS (one thing I need from you next week):

A: _____

B: _____

WEEKLY CHECK-IN - WEEK 3

Date: ___/___/___ Set aside 20 min. No phones. Face each other.

ROSES (good things this week):

Partner A: _____

Partner B: _____

THORNS (challenges this week):

Partner A: _____

Partner B: _____

BUDS (things to look forward to):

Together: _____

APPRECIATION (one specific thing I appreciated about you):

A to B: _____

B to A: _____

NEEDS (one thing I need from you next week):

A: _____

B: _____

WEEKLY CHECK-IN - WEEK 4

Date: ____/____/____ Set aside 20 min. No phones. Face each other.

ROSES (good things this week):

Partner A: _____

Partner B: _____

THORNS (challenges this week):

Partner A: _____

Partner B: _____

BUDS (things to look forward to):

Together: _____

APPRECIATION (one specific thing I appreciated about you):

A to B: _____

B to A: _____

NEEDS (one thing I need from you next week):

A: _____

B: _____

WEEKLY CHECK-IN - WEEK 5

Date: ___/___/___ Set aside 20 min. No phones. Face each other.

ROSES (good things this week):

Partner A: _____

Partner B: _____

THORNS (challenges this week):

Partner A: _____

Partner B: _____

BUDS (things to look forward to):

Together: _____

APPRECIATION (one specific thing I appreciated about you):

A to B: _____

B to A: _____

NEEDS (one thing I need from you next week):

A: _____

B: _____

7-DAY APPRECIATION PRACTICE

Every day for 7 days, tell your partner ONE specific thing you appreciate about them. Write it here AND say it out loud.

Day 1 Date: ____/____/____

I appreciate: _____

Their reaction: _____

Day 2 Date: ____/____/____

I appreciate: _____

Their reaction: _____

Day 3 Date: ____/____/____

I appreciate: _____

Their reaction: _____

Day 4 Date: ____/____/____

I appreciate: _____

Their reaction: _____

Day 5 Date: ____/____/____

I appreciate: _____

Their reaction: _____

Day 6 Date: ____/____/____

I appreciate: _____

Their reaction: _____

Day 7 Date: ____/____/____

I appreciate: _____

Their reaction: _____

After 7 days, how has our connection changed?

LOVE LANGUAGE DISCOVERY

Rank each love language 1-5 (1 = most important to you):

PARTNER A:

- ___ Words of Affirmation (compliments, encouragement, 'I love you')
- ___ Quality Time (undivided attention, being together, date nights)
- ___ Physical Touch (hugs, holding hands, physical closeness)
- ___ Acts of Service (doing helpful things, taking tasks off their plate)
- ___ Receiving Gifts (thoughtful presents, tokens of love, surprises)

PARTNER B:

- ___ Words of Affirmation (compliments, encouragement, 'I love you')
- ___ Quality Time (undivided attention, being together, date nights)
- ___ Physical Touch (hugs, holding hands, physical closeness)
- ___ Acts of Service (doing helpful things, taking tasks off their plate)
- ___ Receiving Gifts (thoughtful presents, tokens of love, surprises)

DISCUSSION:

My #1 love language is: _____

I feel most loved when you: _____

I feel LEAST loved when you: _____

One way to speak my language this week: _____

EMOTIONAL BID RESPONSE TRACKER

An 'emotional bid' is any attempt to connect (a touch, question, comment, or look). You can TURN TOWARD, TURN AWAY, or TURN AGAINST.

Track your responses for one week:

Day 1

Bid made by: A / B What they did/said: _____

Response: ☐ Turned toward (engaged) ☐ Turned away (ignored) ☐ Against (snapped)

Day 2

Bid made by: A / B What they did/said: _____

Response: ☐ Turned toward (engaged) ☐ Turned away (ignored) ☐ Against (snapped)

Day 3

Bid made by: A / B What they did/said: _____

Response: ☐ Turned toward (engaged) ☐ Turned away (ignored) ☐ Against (snapped)

Day 4

Bid made by: A / B What they did/said: _____

Response: ☐ Turned toward (engaged) ☐ Turned away (ignored) ☐ Against (snapped)

Day 5

Bid made by: A / B What they did/said: _____

Response: ☐ Turned toward (engaged) ☐ Turned away (ignored) ☐ Against (snapped)

Day 6

Bid made by: A / B What they did/said: _____

Response: ☐ Turned toward (engaged) ☐ Turned away (ignored) ☐ Against (snapped)

Day 7

Bid made by: A / B What they did/said: _____

Response: ☐ Turned toward (engaged) ☐ Turned away (ignored) ☐ Against (snapped)

TOTALS: Turned toward: ____ Away: ____ Against: ____

Goal: Turn toward 80%+ of bids. This builds trust over time.

OUR COMMUNICATION AGREEMENTS

We agree to the following rules for how we communicate:

1. We will not use contempt (eye-rolling, mocking, name-calling)
2. We will take a time-out when either of us is flooded
3. Our time-out signal is: _____
4. We will use 'I' statements instead of 'you' accusations
5. We will not bring up past issues that have been resolved
6. We will not argue in front of our children
7. We will have a weekly check-in on: _____
8. We will express appreciation daily
9. We will assume positive intent before reacting
10. We will _____
11. We will _____
12. We will _____

Signed:

Partner A: _____ Date: ____/____/____

Partner B: _____ Date: ____/____/____

DATE NIGHT CONVERSATION STARTERS

50 questions to deepen connection. Pick 2-3 per date night.

1. What is your happiest memory of us?
2. What are you most looking forward to?
3. When do you feel most loved by me?
4. What is a dream you have not told me?
5. What is something new you want to try?
6. How can I better support you right now?
7. What do you wish we did more of together?
8. What attracted you to me at first?
9. What is your biggest worry right now?
10. Where do you see us in 10 years?
11. What is one thing I do that makes you smile?
12. What is something small I could do daily?
13. What does 'home' mean to you?
14. What is your favorite way to relax?
15. What would your perfect day look like?
16. What is a childhood memory that shaped you?
17. How do you want to grow as a person?
18. What scares you most about the future?
19. What makes you feel most alive?
20. What is something you admire about me?
21. If money was not an issue, what would change?
22. What tradition should we start?
23. What is the best gift I ever gave you?
24. How do you want to be loved when sad?
25. What is a goal we should pursue together?
26. What song reminds you of us?
27. What is your love language today?
28. What do you need more of from me?
29. What adventure should we plan?
30. What have I taught you about life?
31. What is your proudest moment?
32. What do you value most in our relationship?
33. What makes you feel safe with me?
34. What is something you want to forgive?
35. What legacy do we want to leave?
36. What is your favorite thing about our home?
37. How can we laugh more together?
38. What is something I do not know about you?
39. What makes our relationship unique?
40. What is the hardest thing about being married?
41. What is the best thing about being married?
42. What is a fear you want to overcome?
43. How do you want to celebrate our anniversary?
44. What do you need more patience with?
45. What is something kind someone did recently?
46. What are you grateful for today?
47. What do you want to be remembered for?
48. How can we serve others together?
49. What surprised you about marriage?
50. Why do you still choose me every day?